

“Physical exhaustion and hernias are common, miners die under collapsed pit walls, and divers sometimes do not resurface. Many miners [...] are vulnerable to malaria and contracting parasites by drinking from streams dirtied by their own excrement” – Amnesty International 2015.

Introduction

Life in Congo is determined by a crucial contradiction: the population lives in one of the most resource-rich lands on earth but is counted as one of the poorest in the world. The reasons for this, originate from a historical, social, and economic process that highlights the deeply rooted patterns of exploitation. Issues such as labor enslavement, fueling rebel wars, and reaping profits from diamond mines in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) have been low on the international radar for decades. It only became a clear priority during the ensuant of civil wars that engulfed the continent from the 1990s, even then the attention only stayed briefly for a decade thereafter until the 2010s. More recently technology rush fixated international attention on the extraction of tin, tungsten, tantalum (3T) and cobalt. However, the diamond mining sector in DRC, past to present has generated insurmountable profits for European nations, particularly Belgium, which remains rather under-researched. The significance of the diamond market is extensive not just in terms of clever marketing – ‘diamond as girl’s best friend’, or as a symbol of ‘purity’ for marriages but huge in terms of capitalized monopoly. Diamond trade in Belgium accounts for the 5th largest industry within the country – 5% of which is exported within the EU and 15% outside the EU. Belgium’s Antwerp – the diamond district traded 46 billion US dollars in 2017 (Sola, n.d.). Much of these diamonds traded in Belgium markets are mined and extracted from DRC with horrendous labor conditions representing modern slavery which is defined as a situation where people are forcefully controlled by others for exploitation (Haider, 2017) and survive on income as little as 1-2 US dollars per day (Maydan, 2018).

We could take the case of diamond extraction in DRC by Belgium as a comprehensive capitalist market economy, but profit imperialism cannot only be viewed as purely capitalist. As Melamed (2015) points out capital accumulation is only possible through severe inequality among human beings. This accumulation requires loss, unequal treatment, disposability of human lives, and racism as a fundamental component. In-depth Cedric Robinson’s *Black Marxism: The Making of a Black Radical Tradition* theorizes that capitalism and racism are neither two separate entities nor one defines the other, instead both coincide – capitalism is racial capitalism. Modern racial capitalism like the historic one entails slavery, violence, imperialism, genocide, and ecological slaughter. All these tactics are practiced in one form or the other by Belgian capitalists towards Congolese laborers.

If capitalism is in fact racial capitalism, then why has much of academic literature about diamond mining revolved around the narrative of the ‘resource curse’? as if the availability of mineral deposits in DRC is the only cause of its century-long misery. Much of Belgium’s role in unethical diamond sourcing throughout the history of DRC had a one-sided interpretation: labor

conditions are an ‘effect’ of capitalism and not in itself a ‘racial cause’ of capitalism. Within these guiding inquiries, the main research question of the paper is formulated: How does Belgium’s continued profit from the global diamond trade in the DRC reflect historical patterns of colonial oppression, and labor exploitation exemplifying the principles of racial capitalism? I argue that the case of diamond extraction in DRC by Belgium is a clear example of capitalism driven by racialization motives – meaning that Belgium’s goal of capital accumulation was confounded in the roots of racism and segregation of the DRC natives. Without the racialization of Congolese workers wealth accumulation in Belgium would not be possible. Colonialism in DRC shows the extreme measures adopted by Belgium exploiting and expropriating natural resources and labor forces alike that translated to imperceptible gains at the cost of millions of Congolese lives. I also argue that we find historical parallels of racial capitalism evident today as Belgium profits off Congolese labor with slave-like working conditions, perpetuating violence, and creating a cycle of economic subjugation and marginalization.

The paper is divided into three different parts: explaining the theory of racial capitalism and how it applies to Belgium’s case of diamond extortion in DRC, providing examples highlighting the historical context, socio-economic dimension, and supply chain of the diamonds. First, the theoretical framework investigates the case of Belgium’s diamond mining in DRC through the lens of racial capitalism put forth by Cedric Robinson. It further contains the bulk of the literature review, research methodology, and the overall analytical framework guided by the theory. Second, the empirical analysis shows the social dimension of labor exploitation, and the economic dimension provides evidence of Belgian wealth past through the present. Finally, the paper ends with alternatives and further scope of research.

Theoretical Framework and Literature Review:

In developing the theoretical framework used to analyze the exemplification of capitalism and labor exploitation in the case of Belgium’s diamond trade through DRC, I drew on the racial capitalism theory proposed by Cedric Robinson in his book *The Black Marxism: The Making of a Black Radical Tradition*. Racial capitalism finds its root in Karl Marx’s theory of the value of labor power that determined their wage, and subsequently adjusted their living standards. However, Robinson in his insights argued that capitalism was historically and structurally linked to race. The term racial capitalism was originally used by South African academics who contended that racism in South Africa during the apartheid era was reinforced by capitalism, which was implemented through a racialized division of labor in which capitalists undervalued the racialized workers to maximize profits. However, Cedric Robinson argued that all capitalism was inherently racial and the role of capitalism in the South African case was not the only isolated one (Gonzalez & Mutua, 2022).

Robinson argued in favor of capitalism's success in Western civilization, rejecting the notion that it negates feudalism. Capitalism was already smeared with racialization with its characteristics such as domination, segregation, exploitation, violence, and genocide. Capitalism

and racism are not two different concepts but have evolved together as a single entity throughout Western history. The first example of racial capitalism at play was in Europe where the Irish, Roma, Jews and Slavs were the victims of its consequences through colonialism, dispossession and slavery (Kelley, 2017). Thus, it can be inferred that racial capitalism through method usages such as colonialism and slavery does not merely divide the workers or homogenize them but instead differentiates them based on region, culture and language as ‘others’, ‘inferiors’ or as ‘racial ones’ and already existed.

Melamed (2015) states that all capitalism is racial capitalism and capital can only be accumulated if it is entrenched with severe inequality among human beings. States play an important role in valuing or devaluing individuals based on their needs. In this context, the state’s racial actions such as dehumanizing working conditions, overworking, underpaying or no pay, seizing possessions and looting natural resources can be legitimized and justified. Racial capitalism thus entails massive whitewashing where the capital/possessions gained through this process can enter another system and appear as clean, neutral and a rightful possession. When we use this analysis in DRC, Belgium since 1885 during the rule of King Leopold II has perpetrated undisguised looting of the resources, the enslavement of the Congolese people and their murder. The resources then flowed freely into Belgium and Europe to be turned into capital. Today, a similar trend ensues regarding diamond mining where mine workers are devalued based on their race, dehumanized and considered disposable. The rhetoric that the labor of the enslaved people is quintessential for the generation of capital, but their lives are expendable is the core problem of racial capitalism highlighted in the study.

According to Gonzalez & Mutua (2022), there are two structural features of racial capitalism, and they are profit-making and race-making to accumulate power and wealth. Profit-making occurs by driving surplus profit using the techniques of exploitation, expropriation and expulsion. Exploitation commodified the labor such that the laboring is deemed free or granted a borderline living wage in exchange for products. Expropriation intensified exploitation where surplus economic profit is generated through enslaved laborers with no payment or resource replenishment time. The most problematic of all is expulsion where laborers are viewed as surplus and can hence be discarded without any repercussions. Race-making then is the social construction where some races are established as superior whereas others inferior. Racial stratification naturalizes all forms of injustices, exploitation, expropriation and expulsion. Based on these fabricated racial identities it is legible for nations to squash others, dehumanize and extract resources endlessly.

Empirical Analysis:

Belgium's historical exploitation of DRC:

DRC's present socio-economic condition is the result of past colonialism, slavery and systemic corruption. Historically Portuguese who arrived in Congo in the 1480s were complacent in the racialization of the labor workforce. The exhaustible supply of strong slaves meant they could be overworked, exploited and quickly replaced. This also happened when King Leopold II of Belgium hacked the vast empire as private property and instilled a rapacious, barbaric rule where the workers were overworked to death to supply rubber and ivory to the Western market. The Belgian colonial rule had no objective of developing the country but had only one goal – to make immense money from what was beneath the earth at the cost of human lives or nature (DR Congo, 2013). The modus operandi of the European colonizers then would have been to dismantle the sophisticated governance or modernity that had already existed in Congo, destroy the aristocracy, disassemble the civil service and demolish communal harmony by inciting racial segregation and conflicts. The divide-and-conquer tactics that many European settlers used to colonize the world were also used leaving the state in utter dysfunction and complete anarchy. If profit-making might have been the ultimate goal, the strategy was racial which heavily depended on the exploitation of labor, creation of racial hierarchy and structural violence.

Lefèvre (2008) recorded that the Belgian King Leopold II undertook his duty to civilize the naïve black Africans, while doing so a racial ideology was underpinned such that Africans were inferior to Europeans and that racial hierarchy was repeatedly used to justify the subjugation of the Congolese people. They were violated structurally as well as denied basic human rights. Racialized power dynamics played an important role in capital accumulation. It is estimated that the total profit accumulated from Belgian Congo by King Leopold II amounted to at least 532.5 million euros in today's currency. Lane (2015), claimed the crimes of Belgians as:

The crime that has been wrought in the Congo lands by King Leopold of Belgium and his followers is the greatest that has ever been known in human annals. [...] Never before has there been such a mixture of wholesale expropriation and wholesale massacre [...] Belgium has not run the colony. It has simply sacked it, forcing the inhabitants without pay to ship everything of value to Antwerp. (p.10)

Belgians through their colonialism in DRC formed long-term ethnic divisions and racial segregation among the people. They oriented social experiments where some blacks were considered 'worthy' or 'evolved' as the Europeans whereas others were not – creating a middle strata between the European masters and the black labor force to further break down any remnants of communal harmony. "In the olden days, we didn't look at other people and say: 'That one there is from Kasai, that one is a Lamba, a Bemba or a Luba.' No. We were together. [...] There was no difference. No one talked about the differences." (Lane, 2015, p.13).

This first European contact with Congo in the 15th century sowed the roots of racial capitalism thus then setting the tone of the country for decades to come. Even after independence, the legacy of Belgium remained as it installed the Belgian-controlled puppet ruler Mobutu, the discovery of the diamond instigated rebel wars, rampant corruption, and violence but also renewed Belgian interest. Using these underlined historical findings, I claim that it has now been even easier for Belgium (and other states such as Israel, India, and Qatar though not the focus of the study) to continue extorting profits out of diamond mines in DRC with continued racial subjugation. I propose that a ‘silent’ racial capitalism is taking place where Belgium does not need to valiantly invade lands, use proxy rulers as in the past, or invest taxes to reap profits. Belgium can remain dormant while funneling scanty investments in the diamond industries of DRC; the external factors present such as rebel groups, middlemen employing small-scale diamond artisans, and lawlessness – though an effect of Belgium’s colonial past (un)fortunately provides a favorable condition for Belgium to keep profiting without much drudgery.

“If I find a big diamond, I will use the money to go to the city to study. Then I could get a job. Any job is better than the mine”- (Sjöström et al., 2016)

Social Dimension of Racial Capitalism:

The legacy of colonialism in DRC and ongoing economic marginalization has created a vacuum that justifies exploitation for the sake of capital accumulation. Racial capitalism is moreover about increased profit over human well-being. Within this profit pursuit, the diamond mining investors or trade companies overlook the laborer's working standards. Laborers are considered cheap and replaceable and thus denied fair wages, safety equipment and the onset of health risks have always been an issue. Diamond miners are on their own, the most precious mineral on earth is extracted from mere old pick, rope, and tattered bags. Safety equipment for extractions even basic ones such as flashlights, gloves, or protective clothing and lack thereof results in accidents and deaths (Galeazzi & Berra, n.d.). The social dimension presents largely the exploitative working conditions of the DRC laborers legitimized by Belgium and intersects with structural violence, gender and health. These intersections will be explored here onwards in the paper.

It has been reported that horrible abuses, violence, and worker exploitation have taken place both among employees of large industries and small artisanal diamond miners. The laborers who work in the mines receive less than 1-2 US dollars per day which is supposed to feed them, and their families and lift the whole community out of poverty. Most of DRC's diamond is mined from a town named Mbuji Mayi, which exports billions of dollars' worth of diamonds that travel across the world but the people there stay poverty-stricken. The diamond miners are systematically cheated and even further cheated by the middlemen (Maydan, 2018). These middlemen buy diamonds from workers at a fraction of the market value, and they are sold to Antwerp, the diamond marketing hub of Belgium (Farah, 2001). These takings are thus viewed as “appropriations without exchange” (Gonzalez & Mutua, 2022, p.144) where workers are left with only pennies for their hard labor. Much of the labor power in DRC is found to be forced labor with no freedom of movement and under armed threat (Haider, 2017), mainly perpetrated by armed rebels but it is important to establish the link between Belgium's role in buying these diamonds from the middlemen or the armed rebels that sustains the exploitative conditions.

Furthermore, there is extra-economic coercion involved in the requisition of unpaid or undervalued labor, and it is justified based on racial and gendered labor, thus it requires a threat beyond the perception of poverty and starvation. According to the DRC Country Profile, in DRC majority of women do not participate in digging, they are largely the transporters and processors associated with ‘care work’. Many of the women in these diamond mines have been subjected to routine examinations where the inspector uses the same gloves and plastic bags for the inspection of vaginal and anal areas of many, making them a vulnerable target to sexually transmitted diseases and HIV. Congolese women have been raped in refusal of such body searches (Le Billon, 2006). Many young children also work as mine laborers with the main aim to earn little money to finance

their education but when they join the industry and start earning, they discontinue their studies (Sjöström et al., 2016). Around 40,000 children work in mines in DRC for up to 12 hours a day with backbreaking labor to afford their and their family's sustenance (Dowling, n.d.). Racial capitalism at the intersection of health harbors troubling results in DRC with the 2016 report of DRC country profile and Joyner (2023) state that there is a lack of sanitation in their makeshift tents, pollution of drinking water from workers own excrement and risk of malarial infections.

All the laborers are on their own, they are working for themselves and there is no diamond mining organization (Maydan, 2018). These labor violations on all accounts of men, women and children, sexual abuse, horrendous living, working and health conditions have not though been exclusively termed as gross human rights violations under the Kimberly Certification Scheme (an initiative to curb rebel-financed blood diamonds and their exports globally). Only the rebel movement undermining governments has been (Galeazzi & Berra, n.d.). Violence directed against Belgian profit-making companies are condemned but the same violence is necessary to keep the labor force in check. This can be a classic example of additive where violence is legitimized, selection not only which but also what kind of violence matters and devaluation of human lives deemed fit if it served the reigning powers (Belgium) as racialized people's lives are expendable.

Economic and Supply Chain dimension - Rocks here fortune elsewhere

The global diamond market production in 1999 was estimated to be between \$6.857 and \$7.253 billion, with DRC having the largest share of industrial diamond production. For example, in 1996, DRC amounted to the exports of 21 million carats of diamonds with \$389 million in value (Cook, 2001). In 2021, DRC exported \$83.1 million to Belgium and most of these diamonds passed through the city of Antwerp in Belgium. 84% of rough diamonds and 50% of polished diamonds go via Antwerp in one form or another. In 2017 the city traded \$46 billion in diamonds across the world (*Democratic Republic of the Congo (COD) and Belgium (BEL) Trade*, n.d.). The data represents the fraction profit that DRC earns in comparison to Belgium's diamond hub. Most of these diamonds are traded off from DRC as raw materials and their price value is equivalent to rocks. The tradeoff is deemed legible as DRC does not have the equipment and craftsmanship to cut and polish raw diamonds for standard retail sales. A prime example of how capitalism operates – is the extortion of resources at a minimal price or even 'free' trade with no intention of developing the skill of the laborers or benefiting the land from which the minerals are extracted.

The supply chain operation of Belgium works in complete and utter secrecy even though there have been many efforts to reform this industry. Diamond imports are hugely based on trust and not official papers. Even though Belgium produces its summary import/export reports many of these are not public or official statistics. Smillie (2002), reports that there is a complete vacuum and an absence of international statistics about diamond trade. Family-owned businesses that are not listed on stock markets make up a large portion of the diamond industry. As a result, they are not subject to corporation law, transparency regulations do not apply to them, and very little of their internal operations are made public. Because of their enormous control over their value chain,

large firms like De Beers and Alrosa hold a disproportionate amount of the world's rough diamond trade and its value. The diamond market in Belgium despite various allegations, of human and labor rights violations remains in a better position because it essentially finances the country's high public debt ratio. Government assures that it remains good in financial papers (Merket, 2021). The diamond trade is highly secretive, with little public information of trade statistics, irregularity, and more unknowns than knowns in its operation. This intricate system highlights that it is almost impossible to establish a connection between the resource extraction companies at the top linking and holding them accountable for the labor and human rights violations on the bottom.

Lab diamonds as an alternative?

A lab-grown diamond is anything that substitutes the diamonds that are extracted from the earth. While a mined diamond is formed from high pressure and temperature beneath the surface after years of carbonization, a lab-grown diamond can be made in a matter of days under similar laboratory conditions. Lab-grown diamonds are chemically identical in the lattice of crystal structures to the mined diamonds. Retailers do not think lab-grown diamonds are "natural" enough, even though they are identical to mined diamonds in terms of chemical, structural, and optical properties (Whiteley, 2016). Maybe because lab-grown diamonds do not possess the same rich history, the amount of work that goes into mining, cutting and tailoring standards which is why the sales of lab-grown diamonds whilst being chemically the same and lower in prices have not replaced the traditional diamond industry. But could be an ethical alternative to the mined diamonds that evoke many humanitarian and environmental issues. Much counterargument to replacing mined diamonds with ethically made lab diamonds revolves around the loss of jobs by laborers that are employed in the mining industry – approximately 10 million people. For them I argue that mined diamonds are naturally occurring resources and are finite, they will deplete shortly and so will the jobs dry up then. But if lab diamonds are highly unpreferred by the customers and replaced then it might create some pressure on the corporation to provide better living and labor conditions from where they are extracted. Until now lab-grown diamonds have not been able to replace the traditional diamond industry but only seek to provide an ethical choice to those who want to purchase diamonds.

Conclusion:

The exploitation of labor and resources in DRC highlights the intricate nature of and exemplifies the dynamics of racial capitalism. The long historical legacy of colonialism, servitude, and violence perpetuated by Belgium combined with contemporary economic structures, has expanded a system where profit accumulation is intertwined with racial hierarchies and segregation. The past and present case of Belgium and its nefarious activity in DRC shows that the pursuit of wealth accumulation relies heavily on the severe inequality and suffering of human beings. These humans preclude the Western white capitalists and always are the 'others' or 'inferiors' but are quintessential for wealth accumulation. The important contradiction that these

inferior humans are essential but also expendable is what the paper tries to illustrate through the lens of racial capitalism and various contemporary examples in DRC imposed by Belgium.

Belgium's extraction of diamonds from DRC is not a neutral economic activity but instead is the continuation of the same historical exploitative practices: racial and economic subjugation. The laborers inclusive of men, women and children live and work in slave-like conditions with minimum or sometimes no repatriation and are treated as disposable commodities. The structural features of racial capitalism do not only intersect with profit and race-making but create more ailment in terms of gendering, health, education and other dimensions. The economic dimension reveals stark asymmetrical power dynamics and economic gaps within the global diamond trade. Even though DRC produces the highest amount of diamonds it ranks lowest in capitalizing that profit for its people. The majority of the profit flows into Belgium as its own legally and admissibly while DRC remains impoverished despite owning abundant diamond resources. Moreover, the secrecy surrounding the diamond supply chain further obscures the accountability of those who commit the exploitation.

While the diamond trade industry is a complex market with less research carried out, limited trade, and public import/export international data creates a vacuum where the crimes of violence and subjugation directed towards laborers hide in plain sight and the cycle continues. An alternative the paper provides is the possibility of awareness towards the diamond consumers to opt for lab-grown diamonds over mined ones. Not even 'ethically sourced' diamonds because once the diamonds are traded off it is impossible to trace the ethical lineage of these diamonds. As mentioned in the social dimension of the paper an important highlight but also a limitation this paper could not address is the research on trade unions in diamond mining. All the workers, men, women and children are on their own, they work for themselves. Like many other industries such as car, meat, and agriculture; the diamond industry has been initiated since the 1900s, it is surprising to see that none of the trade unions have emerged for the protection and escalation of the rights of laborers in diamond mines in DRC and other parts of Africa nor have the Western countries advocated for it. Why is this so? It further proves the point elaborated in the paper earlier that one of the hindsight objectives of racial capitalism is to control who gets what, provide selection not only which but also what kind of violence matters and to whom that violence is directed, based on it the possibility of justice and devaluation of human lives deemed fit if it served the reigning powers. Instances such as these and many others highlighted in the paper portray evidence of the racialization of workers at play for capital accumulation. In light of these findings, addressing the systemic injustices inherent in the diamond trade requires acknowledging and challenging the racialized structures that underpin it. Efforts to reform the industry must prioritize the rights and well-being of the DRC's laborers and communities, rather than prioritizing profit accumulation at their expense. Ultimately, confronting the legacy of racial capitalism in the diamond trade demands a collective commitment to dismantling the structural inequalities and injustices that perpetuate exploitation and marginalization in the DRC and beyond.

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